contemporaries and potential foes. In this vein, he could come across as unambitious and parochial, but in reality he turned into a savvy and ruthless dictator. Than Shwe was officially sworn in as SLORC chairman on April 23, 1992.

Than Shwe's early career actually mirrors that of Ne Win. They both started in governmental positions as postal clerks and later both were involved in the psychological-warfare component of the tatmadaw. Once he assumed power, Shwe began holding secret late-night cabinet meetings with key members of the tatmadaw who would eventually become his key loyalists. Future leader Thein Sein would be included in this late-night leadership faction. On several occasions, Than Shwe informally called on Ne Win to get his approval for projects that were being undertaken. Though he did not in any way have a power base that could threaten Shwe, it was considered respectful to consult with him and probably help to establish his creditability and legitimacy within the ranks of the military. Ne Win gave his blessings to the direction in which Than Shwe was taking Myanmar.

As Than Shwe assumed the position of head of the army, defense chief, head of SLORC, and prime minister, his power was unmatched. Considered a drab and uninspiring figure, Than Shwe was firm and more of a hardliner on policy than his predecessor. Later, Shwe would purge Nyunt, who was eventually charged with insubordination, corruption, and dereliction of duty. Many of his associates within the military intelligence organization were imprisoned, while Nyunt was allowed to retire because of ill health. This event was the culmination of a power struggle between the military and intelligence agencies. In the end, the entire military intelligence operation was abolished with Shwe claiming this to be a major step in cleaning up corruption and mismanagement within the state of Myanmar.

The NLD attempted to negotiate in a constructive manner with Than Shwe. The refusal to transfer power to the rightfully elected government was the main point of contention. Furthermore, the NLD and Chairman Aung Shwe felt that the regime continually stonewalled the movement and delayed any substantive meetings regarding the democratic transition process. These tactics delayed the formation of a national parliament in line with the election results of 1990. Genuine negotiations in reality were never held. The strategy was of course to show the futility in supporting the NLD. In order to promote the façade of having an inclusionary policy, Than Shwe